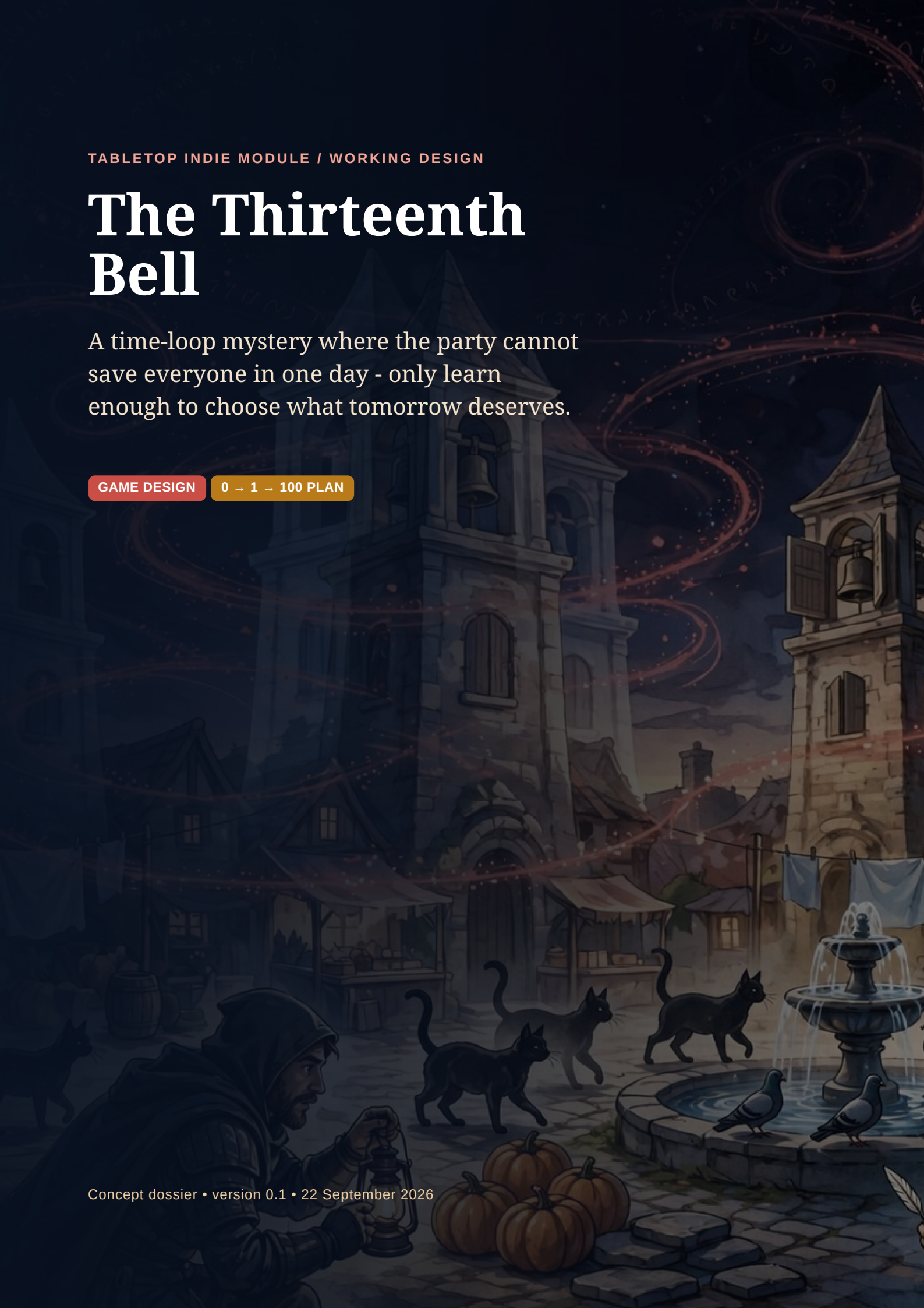
TABLETOP INDIE MODULE / WORKING DESIGN

The Thirteenth Bell

A time-loop mystery where the party cannot save everyone in one day - only learn enough to choose what tomorrow deserves.

GAME DESIGN

0 → 1 → 100 PLAN



Concept dossier • version 0.1 • 22 September 2026

EXECUTIVE DECISION

Build the module first; treat Steam as the sequel to validated play

The smallest compelling product is a 3-5 session tabletop mystery set in one repeating day. The business goal is not “finish a giant book.” It is to prove that players voluntarily plan one more loop.

0
UNKNOWN FUN
Start with paper, eight non-player characters, six locations, and one catastrophic reset.

1
COMPLETE PRODUCT
Ship one playable PDF with tested handouts, a facilitator dashboard, and a clear ending.

100
EVIDENCE THRESHOLD
Reach 100 verified plays or owners before funding a standalone digital adaptation.

Product promise

Every loop changes the players, even when the world resets. Knowledge is the primary currency; relationships, objects, and injuries persist only when deliberately anchored.

Recommended format

- 3-5 players plus one Game Master.
- Three to five sessions, 2.5-3.5 hours each.
- System-light core with optional fifth-edition-compatible encounter notes.
- Digital PDF first; print-on-demand only after layout proof.

Why this scope

- A single town concentrates writing and art.
- A deterministic schedule makes repetition legible.
- Branching comes from route choice, not hundreds of pages.
- A digital tabletop prototype can test usability before bespoke software.

Decision gate: proceed only if at least 3 of 4 blind groups ask to run another loop without prompting, can explain the central problem, and complete a reset in under three minutes.

GAME THESIS

The fun comes from prediction, not repetition



1. Learn

Observe a fixed schedule, test a theory, and expose a contradiction.

2. Plan

Use known events to split the party, intercept people, and stage precise interventions.

3. Choose

Spend limited anchors and accept that preserving one truth may erase another.

Four design pillars

- **Knowledge is power:** facts open routes more reliably than levels or loot.
- **Failure creates information:** a lost fight should reveal timing, motive, or consequence.
- **Repetition compresses:** solved scenes become fast-travel cards, never compulsory reenactments.
- **The final answer is moral:** the last loop asks what deserves to persist.

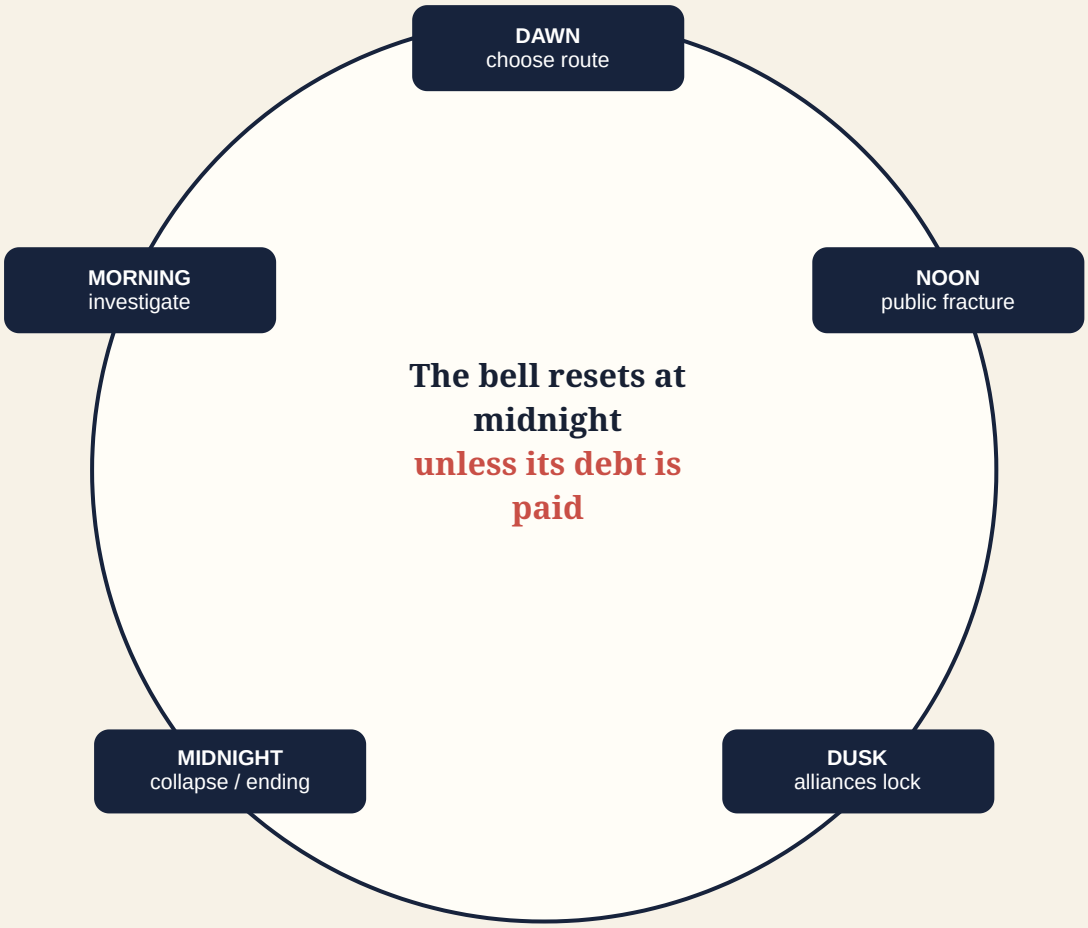
Explicit anti-pillars

- No pixel-hunting for one “correct” clue.
- No reset that erases player notes or agency.
- No mandatory combat grind.
- No surprise ending that depends on information the table could not discover.

> **Design hypothesis H1:** players will experience mastery when they predict a scheduled event before the Game Master announces it. **Evidence:** tally unprompted predictions per loop; the median should rise after loop two.

CORE LOOP

A day has five phases and one irreversible question



Orient	Commit	Intervene	Reckon	Reset
Recall anchors	Choose 2 routes	Change events	See fallout	Keep 1 anchor

Table economy

Each phase gives the party **two spotlight actions**. A group action moves everyone; a split action resolves two locations with a cost: the Game Master advances one off-screen event.

Reset economy

At reset, the party retains all player knowledge but may preserve only **one physical anchor** and **one relationship anchor**. Scars always persist.

Design hypothesis H2: five named phases create urgency without minute-by-minute bookkeeping. **Evidence:** fewer than two timing clarifications per session and no more than one stalled route choice over five minutes.

PLAYABLE WORLD

Six locations are enough when every place changes with the clock

Bell Square

Public ceremonies, the first fracture, and the final ritual. The obvious center hides a false history.

Glassworks

The town's wealth and the source of echo-crystal. Workers remember dreams they never lived.

Saint Orra's Hospice

Victims wake with yesterday's wounds. Its ledger exposes who has been reset before.

Flooded Archive

Records survive only below the waterline. Access requires timing the sluice gate.

North Gate

A caravan enters at noon carrying a child who does not reset with the town.

Underbell

The engine beneath the tower can end the loop, transfer it, or widen it.

Town event matrix

Place	Dawn	Noon	Dusk	Midnight
Square	Market opens	Bell cracks	Curfew	Time wave
Glassworks	Shift change	Strike vote	Furnace breach	Crystal sings
Hospice	Blank patient	Ledger stolen	Ward sealed	Old wounds return
Archive	Gate dry	Flood begins	Records surface	Ink reverses
North Gate	Closed	Caravan arrives	Guard mutiny	Road vanishes
Underbell	Dormant	First pulse	Custodian wakes	Choice unlocked

> **Writing rule:** every cell must offer at least one clue, one leverage point, or one cost. If it offers only atmosphere, fold it into another scene.

MYSTERY ARCHITECTURE

Three questions turn each failed loop into progress

01

What happens?

At midnight the bell freezes the town, shatters, and restores dawn. The characters wake with memory intact.

Reveal by loop 1
Clear consequence

02

Who benefits?

Magistrate Vale renews the day to prevent the caravan child from revealing the town's founding crime.

Reveal by loop 2-3
Motive + access

03

What is the cost of escape?

The engine can release the town only by restoring thirteen stolen years to their original owners, aging some residents and reviving buried grief.

Reveal before finale
Choice + consent

Clue redundancy: the three-route rule

Truth	Route A	Route B	Route C
Vale operates the bell	Wax on gloves	Archive signature	Custodian names her
Child resists reset	She remembers party	No hospice echo	Caravan diary
Years were stolen	Birth records mismatch	Portraits do not age	Glassworker dreams

Good reveal

Confirms a theory and unlocks a new action.

Avoid

A lore dump that changes no possible decision.

Design hypothesis H3: three independent routes prevent a single missed roll from stalling the scenario. **Evidence:** blind groups reach each required truth through at least two different routes across the test set.

CAST AND PRESSURE

Every character wants tomorrow - but not the same tomorrow

Character	Public face	Private need	Loop behavior
Magistrate Elian Vale	Calm protector	Keep the founding crime buried	Moves the bell key at dusk
Mara Quill	Glassworkers' organizer	Save workers from the furnace	Calls a strike at noon
Brother Senn	Hospice keeper	End the recurring pain	Burns the ledger at dusk
Ilyra Voss	Town archivist	Prove her own missing years	Opens sluice at noon
Toma Reed	Gate captain	Protect his reset-proof child	Turns on Vale after curfew
Nim	Caravan child	Be believed	Draws prior loops at dawn
The Custodian	Underbell guardian	Transfer the burden	Wakes after three anchors
Old Pera	Market storyteller	Remember the life she lost	Changes one story per loop

Civic order

Vale, guards, and merchants value stability. They can open doors but conceal the cost.

Glassworkers

Mara and the strikers value truth and safety. Their action changes the noon timeline.

Remembered

Nim, Pera, and the Custodian carry fragments across loops and disagree about release.

Portrayal rule: give each named character one repeated gesture, one line that changes after trust, and one action they take without the heroes. Agency makes the town feel alive.

PLAYER-FACING SYSTEM

The Anchor Board turns memory into a shared tactical object

Four card types

- **Facts:** always persist as player knowledge; no slot needed.
- **Bonds:** an NPC begins the next loop trusting one character. Costs one relationship slot.
- **Objects:** one item crosses dawn. Costs one physical slot and gains an Echo tag.
- **Scars:** consequences that always persist until confronted. They are not chosen.



Momentum and Fracture

The party gains **Momentum** when it correctly predicts a scheduled event or connects two clues. Spend 2 Momentum to skip a mastered scene and take its known result. The town gains **Fracture** when a paradox is forced, an anchored object is duplicated, or a character dies. At 4 Fracture, advance one catastrophe early.

Anchor prompt

“What must tomorrow remember?” The answer must name a person or object and why it matters.

Scar prompt

“What did this victory cost?” A scar should change an available choice, not merely impose a numeric penalty.

Reset procedure (target: 180 seconds): freeze the scene → read the catastrophe line → mark one scar → choose one bond and one object → clear event cards → return the clock to dawn → ask for the next route.

Design hypothesis H4: a physical board reduces note-management friction.
Evidence: in blind tests, players can state current anchors and next objective without asking the Game Master to recap.

GAME MASTER OPERATIONS

Run the clock, expose consequences, never protect a plot

Before play

1. Place six location cards around the clock.
2. Stack each location's five event cards in time order.
3. Put the three required truths face down.
4. Ask each character why they fear being forgotten.
5. Choose lines, veils, and pause tools with the group.

During a phase

1. State the visible change.
2. Ask where the party commits attention.
3. Resolve intent; reveal clues even on a failed check, but attach risk or cost.
4. Move unattended events.
5. Advance the clock in view.

Information discipline

- **Telegraph:** show danger before it becomes unavoidable.
- **Repeat:** keep known events stable unless the party changed a cause.
- **Track:** note every deviation on the current-loop sheet.
- **Answer:** distinguish “you do not know yet” from “the world is inconsistent.”

Compression rule

Once a scene is mastered, the table may declare the known approach, pay its established cost, and take the result. Replaying is optional when a new intention or emotional beat matters.

Fail-forward template

You get the information, but... time advances; an NPC sees you; Fracture rises; the clue is incomplete; or the next route becomes more dangerous. Never hide a required truth behind one successful roll.

Session rhythm

10 min	25 min	35 min	35 min	25 min
Recap & anchors	Dawn / morning	Noon crisis	Dusk routes	Midnight & reset

Facilitator load target: the Game Master should consult only the current phase spread, not search across the book. If a test GM flips backward more than three times in a loop, redesign navigation.

CHALLENGES AND PACING

Combat is a clock-changing choice, not the default verb



Conflict

Use short, objective-based encounters: hold the gate for three rounds, rescue two workers, or reach the bell before the pulse.

Social leverage

NPCs do not change because of one high roll. Players need a relevant fact, bond, or sacrifice; the roll decides cost and nuance.

Exploration

Locations reveal different layers by phase. Time, tools, and learned access routes matter more than searching every square.

Encounter budget for the full module

Type	Count	Design constraint
Set-piece conflicts	4	One objective; 3 rounds
Social pressure scenes	8	Leverage changes outcome
Timed hazards	6	Known route can bypass
Quiet revelations	5	Choice follows information

Compatibility approach: keep the scenario's logic system-light. Put Armor Class, Difficulty Class, hit points, and creature substitutions in sidebars or an appendix. That lets the mystery survive balance changes and makes later digital conversion cleaner.

FINALE

The ending should reveal what the campaign was really about

Release the years

The town moves forward. Stolen time returns at once: some regain lives, others age, and every concealed grief becomes real.

Requires: three truths + consent of two factions.

Choose a keeper

One willing person binds the loop to memory rather than repetition. The day continues, but the keeper remembers every lost version.

Requires: Custodian bond + voluntary sacrifice.

Break the town free

The loop transfers to the bell itself, becoming a portable prison. The town lives, while the party carries a dangerous artifact forward.

Requires: three Echo objects + Fracture below 4.

Ending quality checklist

- ☐ Players can name the cost before committing.
- ☐ At least two endings remain viable when the finale begins.
- ☐ No non-player character “chooses for” the party.
- ☐ Each anchor changes one epilogue beat.
- ☐ The last image answers the characters' fear of being forgotten.

Design hypothesis H5: a moral choice creates a stronger ending than a single mechanical solution. **Evidence:** after play, ask each player what they chose, what it cost, and what they would choose differently. A comprehensible ending produces specific answers without GM correction.

Optional campaign bridge: the portable bell, the surviving keeper, or the returned years can seed a longer campaign - but the module itself must feel complete.

PRODUCT ARCHITECTURE

The book is a table tool, not a lore archive

Core PDF: 36-44 pages

- 2 pages: premise, consent, and setup.
- 4 pages: rules and reset procedure.
- 12 pages: six locations, one spread each.
- 8 pages: cast, factions, and schedule.
- 6 pages: clue graph and endings.
- 4-12 pages: reference, handouts, optional stats.

At-the-table kit

- Town map and five-phase clock.
- 30 event cards.
- 18 clue cards.
- 8 character tent cards.
- Anchor Board and reset sheet.
- One-page Game Master dashboard.

Minimum accessibility

- High-contrast print option.
- Patterns plus colors for card types.
- Readable body type and tagged headings.
- Plain-text handout pack.
- No required clue encoded only in art.

Digital tabletop build

- Snap zones for location and clue cards.
- Visible phase tracker.
- Script only reset housekeeping; never automate choices.
- Upload multiplayer assets to cloud storage before Workshop testing; local assets are not suitable for multiplayer sharing.[1]

> **Scope lock:** version 1 contains one town, one day, three endings, and no character class. Expansion ideas go into a parking lot until the blind beta passes.

[1] Tabletop Simulator's documentation distinguishes local assets from cloud-hosted assets for multiplayer and requires a thumbnail for Workshop upload. See Sources.

EVIDENCE PLAN

Playtests decide what survives

Test in four passes

Pass	Question	Sample	Pass signal
Paper pulse	Will they choose another loop?	3 groups	2+ voluntary re-loops
Internal alpha	Does the mystery stay unstuck?	5 sessions	No hard stalls
External beta	Can another GM run it?	4 blind groups	3 complete unaided
Release candidate	Is the artifact usable?	8 readers / 3 runs	No severity-1 issues

Observe, do not defend

- Time to first meaningful choice.
- Minutes spent resetting.
- Unprompted predictions.
- Repeated scenes players skip.
- Required clues recovered.
- Questions the GM cannot answer from the spread.

Ask after play

1. What did you think caused the loop?
2. When did you feel clever?
3. When did repetition become work?
4. Which choice felt irreversible?
5. Would you schedule the next session?

Severity and action

S1: blocks play

Missing clue, unclear reset, unusable map. Fix before next test.

S2: harms choice

False option, hidden cost, dominant route. Fix within two revisions.

S3: polish

Wording, flavor, minor layout. Batch after structure stabilizes.

Kill criterion: after two structural revisions, if most groups still describe the reset as “doing the same thing again,” stop expanding and redesign the core loop.

Six gates convert the concept into one sellable module

0A	**Promise prototype** One-page rules, six location cards, one reset, two endings. Run a 60-minute slice.	Exit: 2/3 groups re-loop
0B	**Scenario skeleton** Write the schedule, clue graph, cast, and three-route redundancy before prose.	Exit: no required single point
0C	**Internal alpha** Add full session arc, encounters, anchors, and all three endings. Test weekly.	Exit: reset < 3 min
0D	**Blind beta** Send files without verbal coaching. Collect GM annotations and session logs.	Exit: 3/4 complete unaided
0E	**Production** Development edit, copyedit, layout, map, cards, accessibility, credits, license review.	Exit: no S1 defects
1	**Release candidate** PDF, printer-friendly pack, one-shot sample, facilitator video script, changelog.	Exit: three clean RC runs

> **Sequence rule:** do not commission final art before 0D. Structural changes are cheap in index cards and expensive after layout.

1 → 100 OPERATION PLAN

Use the first hundred as a learning cohort, not a vanity metric

1 → 10: prove strangers can run it

Recruit ten groups outside the creator's circle. Give each the same package. Offer a short onboarding call only after their first attempt. Publish a public issue log and revision cadence.

Owner or GM email | Session completed | Permissioned quote

10 → 30: prove the promise travels

Release the first loop as a free quickstart. Run streamed or recorded actual plays only with explicit participant consent. Ask partners to describe the game in their own words; compare those words with the product promise.

Quickstart downloads | Completed loops | Next-session intent

30 → 60: prove conversion

Offer the paid module and a facilitator bundle. Test one price at a time; do not infer elasticity from tiny samples. Track refunds, support questions, and which preview pages drive purchase.

Paid owners | Refund reasons | GM activation

60 → 100: prove repeatability

Ship one meaningful update based on observed issues, not a content dump. Add the digital tabletop prototype, a translation-ready text export, and community-run play windows.

Return sessions | Workshop subscribers | Update adoption

≥70%
TARGET COMPLETION
Internal decision threshold, not an industry benchmark.

≤3m
TARGET RESET
Measure from catastrophe line to next route choice.

100
QUALIFIED SIGNALS
Count verified plays or paid owners; report them separately.

STEAM STRATEGY

Steam offers two routes; only one belongs in phase one

Route A: Tabletop Simulator Workshop

Purpose: distribution and multiplayer usability test for the tabletop module.

- Build cards, board, tokens, and a minimal reset script.
- Cloud-host shared assets; local files are not multiplayer-ready.[1]
- Add a thumbnail, clear rules, player count, and accurate tags; the upload flow requires a thumbnail and defaults new mods to hidden, which supports a private verification pass.[1]
- Measure subscriptions separately from completed sessions.

Recommendation: do this after the PDF blind beta.

Route B: standalone Steam game

Purpose: a native digital adaptation, not merely the PDF inside an executable.

- Budget a separate interaction design, save state, tutorials, accessibility, QA, and platform assets.
- Steam Direct currently charges US$100 per app and recoups it after US$1,000 in adjusted gross revenue.[2]
- A new product's Coming Soon page must be live for at least two weeks before release.[3]
- Steam Playtest uses a separate child appID and can gate access without affecting the main product's user reviews or wishlists.[4]

Recommendation: decide only after 100 qualified tabletop signals.

Decision rule at 100: greenlight a standalone prototype only if players value the loop itself, not just the Game Master's performance; at least 20 groups complete the module; and support requests reveal automatable friction.

Avoid the false shortcut: a Workshop item lives inside Tabletop Simulator. A standalone Steam release is its own app, onboarding, store page, build, and review path.[1-4]

RIGHTS, BUDGET, AND RISK

Protect the future digital version by owning the creative core

Rights track

- Own the setting, plot, names, art direction, characters, map, and time-loop rules.
- If using fifth-edition rules text, select one named System Reference Document (SRD) version, copy only covered material, and include its required attribution. D&D Beyond states that SRD 5.1 and 5.2 are available under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 and may be used commercially with attribution.[5]
- Do not assume a rulebook term, monster, setting, logo, or trade dress is included merely because it appears in D&D.
- Keep an asset register: creator, license, source file, allowed uses, payment, and release.

This is production guidance, not legal advice. A publisher or lawyer should review final compatibility language and third-party licenses.

Lean budget model

Illustrative planning assumptions, not market quotes. Replace with vendor bids before spending.

Bucket	Lean range
Development + copy edit	$800-$2,000
Map + key art	$700-$2,500
Layout + accessibility	$500-$1,500
Playtest honoraria	$300-$800
Contingency	15%

Risk register

Risk	Early signal	Mitigation
Repetition becomes labor	Scenes replay verbatim	Mastery skip + route compression
Mystery stalls	One missed clue blocks action	Three-route redundancy
GM overload	Frequent page hunting	Phase spreads + dashboard
Scope expands	New districts before beta	One-town scope lock
IP ambiguity	Unlogged borrowed term	Asset/SRD register + review
Steam distraction	Code before table proof	100-signal decision gate

IMMEDIATE ACTION

Fourteen days to a playable answer

Days 1-3: assemble

- ☐ Write the catastrophe in 120 words.
- ☐ Create six location cards and five phase cards.
- ☐ Draft eight NPC wants and schedules.
- ☐ Draw the three-truth clue graph.

Days 4-7: test the pulse

- ☐ Run three 60-minute tests.
- ☐ Do not explain beyond the one-page rules.
- ☐ Record route choices, predictions, and reset time.
- ☐ Cut any scene that yields no clue, leverage, or cost.

Days 8-11: revise structure

- ☐ Add mastery skips and Anchor Board.
- ☐ Repair every single-point clue.
- ☐ Write two full endings and outline the third.
- ☐ Create the one-page GM dashboard.

Days 12-14: decide

- ☐ Run one blind-facilitated test.
- ☐ Score the five design hypotheses.
- ☐ Choose: proceed, revise core, or stop.
- ☐ If proceeding, schedule 0B and recruit external GMs.

Definition of success on day 14

A new Game Master can run one full loop from the packet; players make at least one correct prediction; reset takes under three minutes; and the group asks to attempt a different route.

First artifact set

1-page rules | 6 location cards | 5 phase cards | 8 NPC cards | clue graph | Anchor Board | GM dashboard | feedback form

Start here: write Dawn, Noon, Dusk, and Midnight on four index cards. Put one irreversible consequence on each. Then invite a group to break the day.

OPERATING DASHBOARD

One scoreboard keeps creative and commercial decisions honest

Measure	Definition	Cadence	Decision use
Voluntary re-loop	Group chooses another loop without prompt	Every test	Core-fun gate
Reset duration	Catastrophe line to next route choice	Every loop	Usability gate
Clue recovery	Required truths found / available truths	Every session	Mystery repair
GM lookup count	Backtracking outside current spread	Blind tests	Book navigation
Completion rate	Groups reaching an ending / groups started	Monthly	Product health
GM activation	Owners who schedule or report a session	Monthly	Onboarding
Support density	Unique issues / completed groups	Per release	Update priority
Qualified signals	Verified completed plays and paid owners, reported separately	Monthly	Steam gate

Weekly review

- Fix all new severity-1 defects.
- Choose one structural question.
- Schedule the next two tests.
- Publish one changelog entry.

Monthly review

- Segment by first-time vs experienced GM.
- Read every refund or abandonment reason.
- Retire metrics that do not change decisions.
- Revisit the 100-signal Steam gate.

Decision bands

Proceed

Targets hold across at least three independent groups and no severity-1 issue repeats.

Iterate

The promise is visible, but friction clusters around one rule, scene, or route.

Stop / pivot

Players do not seek another loop after two structural revisions, or the GM must manufacture momentum.

Evidence hygiene: keep raw notes, session date, build version, group experience, and whether the creator facilitated. Never combine Workshop subscriptions, downloads, purchases, and completed plays into one “community” number.

SOURCES AND EVIDENCE NOTES

Platform facts are sourced; design targets remain testable hypotheses

The module mechanics, targets, budgets, and milestone thresholds in this dossier are original planning assumptions. They are intentionally framed as hypotheses or internal gates, not industry benchmarks. Platform and licensing facts below were checked against first-party documentation on 22 September 2026.

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[1] Tabletop Simulator Knowledge Base - Steam Workshop. Supports the Workshop upload flow, cloud-vs-local asset guidance, required thumbnail, metadata, and hidden default. https://kb.tabletopsimulator.com/custom-content/steam-workshop/

[2] Steamworks Documentation - Steam Direct Fee. Supports the US$100 per-app fee and recoupment after US$1,000 adjusted gross revenue. https://partner.steamgames.com/doc/gettingstarted/appfee

[3] Steamworks Documentation - Coming Soon. Supports the requirement that a new product's Coming Soon page be public for at least two weeks before release. https://partner.steamgames.com/doc/store/coming_soon

[4] Steamworks Documentation - Steam Playtest. Supports the separate child appID, access controls, and separation from main-game reviews and wishlists. https://partner.steamgames.com/doc/features/playtest

[5] D&D Beyond - System Reference Document v5.2.1. Supports that SRD 5.1 and 5.2 are available under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0, commercial use is permitted with attribution, and compatibility between versions is the creator's responsibility. https://www.dndbeyond.com/srd

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Research boundary

No market-size, conversion-rate, “typical budget,” or sales forecast is asserted. The lean budget ranges are working estimates and must be replaced by vendor quotes. The proposed 70% completion target, three-minute reset target, and 100-signal gate are internal choices designed to force a decision; they are not external benchmarks.

Working assumption to confirm

This plan assumes the intended Steam path begins with a Tabletop Simulator Workshop build and may later become a standalone digital adaptation. If the goal is instead to sell only a PDF or virtual-tabletop asset pack, the channel plan should be revised before production.